SAMPLE

The Cave: The Sleepers

The Cave (الكهف) in the Quran

Aira Aurora

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Introduction

The Quran tells the story of a cave -- a cave that was not a place of the destruction but a place of the preservation. In a Book filled with the stories of the cities that were warned and destroyed, the cave is the place where the few were saved -- not by the ark on the water, not by the departure in the night, but by the sleep that was the mercy. The cave is the place where the young men who believed in Allah fled from the society that rejected the faith, and where Allah preserved them for centuries by the sleep that was the protection.

The Quran says:

"Or have you thought that the companions of the cave and the inscription were a wonder among Our signs? When the youths retreated to the cave and said: Our Lord, give us from Yourself a mercy and prepare for us from our affair right guidance" (18:9-10).

The cave is the place of the retreat -- the retreat from the society that has abandoned the faith. The cave is the place of the prayer -- the prayer of the young men who asked Allah for the mercy and the guidance. The cave is the place of the sleep -- the sleep that was not the death but the preservation, the sleep that lasted for centuries and that was the sign for the generations. The cave is the place of the awakening -- the awakening that was the return to the world that had changed, the awakening that was the test of the faith, and the awakening that was the lesson for the people who had forgotten.

This book -- the tenth in the Places in the Qur'an series -- covers the Cave: its name, its sleepers, their flight, their sleep, their awakening, their discovery, its lessons, and its connections to the other sacred places. The book follows the same approach as the first nine books -- Makkah: The Holy City, Madinah: The City of the Prophet, Al-Quds: The Night Journey, Egypt: The Land of Pharaoh, Mount Judi: The Resting Place, Iram: The Lost City, Madyan: The Land of Shu'ayb, Sodom: The Cities of Lut, and Nineveh: The City of Yunus -- exploring the place as the Quran presents it.

The Places in the Qur'an series traces the sacred geography of the Quran. The nine previous books explored the centers of worship, community, tradition, trial, survival, transience, commerce, immorality, and repentance. This tenth book explores the Cave -- the center of the preservation. The ten places are the ten dimensions of the sacred geography: the House, the community, the tradition, the test, the survival, the transience, the commerce, the immorality, the repentance, and the preservation. The person who understands the ten understands that the places where Allah acted are the places that teach -- and the cave that preserved the believers is the cave that teaches that the faith that is held in the isolation is the faith that is preserved by the mercy.

The Cave is the tenth pillar of the sacred geography -- the pillar that teaches that the person who flees to Allah with the faith is the person who is preserved by Allah with the mercy, and the cave that was the hiding place is the cave that became the sign.

Chapter 1: The Name -- The Cave in the Quran

The Cave (Al-Kahf) is the name of the eighteenth surah of the Quran. The surah takes its name from the story of the young men who retreated to the cave -- the "companions of the cave" (ashab al-kahf). The name is the significance: the surah that is named after the cave is the surah whose central story is the cave. The name is the lesson: the cave that was the hiding place is the place that is honored with the name -- and the hiding place that was the refuge is the place that is the title. The person who reads the surah should know: the cave that was the secret place is the place that is now the public sign, and the place that was the hiding is the place that is now the teaching.

The Quran refers to the young men as the "companions of the cave" (18:9). The companions are the significance: the young men who retreated to the cave are identified by the cave -- the cave that was their shelter, their refuge, and their sign. The companions are the lesson: the person who is identified by the place is the person whose story is tied to the place. The young men who are known as the companions of the cave are the young men whose identity is not in their names or their lineage but in their cave -- the cave that was the place of the faith.

The Quran mentions "the companions of the cave and the inscription" (18:9). The inscription is the significance: the Quran connects the cave and the inscription -- the written record that was associated with the story. The inscription is the lesson: the story that was written is the story that was preserved. The young men who retreated to the cave were the young men whose story was inscribed -- inscribed on a tablet, inscribed in the memory, and inscribed in the Book that endures. The inscription is the record: the cave that was the place of the preservation was also the place of the recording -- and the recording that was made is the recording that is read.

The Quran says:

"Or have you thought that the companions of the cave and the inscription were a wonder among Our signs?" (18:9).

The wonder is the significance: the story of the cave is described as a wonder -- a marvel among the signs of Allah. The wonder is the lesson: the preservation of the sleepers is the sign that is wondrous -- the sign that shows the power of Allah to preserve the believers through the sleep that lasted for centuries. The person who reads the story should know: the sleep that preserved the young men is the sleep that is the wonder, and the wonder that is the preservation is the wonder that is the sign of the power of the Preserver.

The Quran mentions the dispute about the number of the sleepers:

"They will say: There were three, the fourth of them being their dog. And they will say: Five, the sixth of them being their dog -- guessing at the unseen. And they will say: Seven, the eighth of them being their dog. Say: My Lord knows their number. None knows them except a few" (18:22).

The number is the significance: the Quran records the dispute about the number of the sleepers -- the dispute that the Quran does not resolve definitively but leaves to Allah. The number is the lesson: the person who argues about the details that Allah has not revealed is the person who has missed the point. The story is not about the number; the story is about the faith -- the faith of the young men who fled to the cave and the preservation of Allah who kept them in the sleep.

The Cave is the only surah in the Quran that is named after a geographical feature that is the setting of a story. The naming is the significance: the surah that is named after the cave is the surah that honors the cave -- the cave that was the place of the preservation. The naming is the lesson: the cave that was the hiding place is the cave that is the title of the surah -- and the title that is the cave is the title that is read by every Muslim who reads the surah. The cave that was once the secret is the cave that is now the public -- the public sign that is read and recited and remembered.

The Cave is the name of Surah Al-Kahf, the eighteenth surah of the Quran. The surah is recited by Muslims every Friday by tradition -- a tradition that connects the weekly recitation to the weekly remembrance of the story. The recitation is the significance: the surah that is named after the cave is the surah that is recited every week -- and the recitation that is the weekly practice is the recitation that keeps the story alive in the memory of the community. The recitation is the lesson: the story that is read regularly is the story that is not forgotten -- and the story that is not forgotten is the story that continues to teach.

Surah Al-Kahf contains not only the story of the sleepers but also the story of the two owners of the garden (18:32-44) and the story of Musa and Khidr (18:60-82). The three stories are the significance: the surah that is named after the cave contains three stories -- and the three stories are the three lessons that are connected by the theme of the trial and the preservation. The three stories are the lesson: the person who reads the surah should read all three -- because the three together teach the complete lesson: the lesson of the faith in the isolation (the cave), the lesson of the humility in the wealth (the garden), and the lesson of the patience in the knowledge (the journey of Musa and Khidr).